

Teen Swimmer Breaks a 23-Year-Old Record!

From: SwimSwam Mined: 2026-06-09 3 min read

Have you ever tried to hold your breath and swim as fast as you can? Imagine doing that while racing against the clock and breaking a record that stood for 23 years! That's exactly what 17-year-old Sienna Toohey did at the Australian Swimming **Trials**. She swam the 100-meter **breaststroke** in just 1 minute and 5.97 seconds. That's super fast! The old record for a 17-year-old was set by **Leisel Jones**, one of the greatest swimmers ever, back in 2003. Leisel's time was 1:06.37. Sienna beat it by almost half a second. Sienna is from Albury, Australia. She had been getting close to the record earlier this year with a time of 1:06.43. But in this race, she exploded off the start and was ahead right from the first 50 meters. Her first half was so fast that no one could catch her. Now Sienna is the third-fastest Australian woman ever in this event. She's also the fastest Australian swimmer in the 100 **breaststroke** since the super-suit **era** ended. **Super-suits** were special swimsuits that helped swimmers go faster, but they were banned in 2010. So Sienna's time is extra impressive. If she keeps swimming like this, she could win medals at the Olympics or **World Championships**. Australia hasn't had a top swimmer in this event for years. Way to go, Sienna!

Word Treasure

breaststroke -- A way of swimming where the arms make a circle and the legs kick out like a frog.

trials -- A competition that decides which swimmers get to represent their country.

super-suits -- Special high-tech swimsuits that helped athletes move faster, banned after 2009.

era -- A long period in history with a special feature, like the super-suit era around 2008.

World Championships -- A big sports event where the best swimmers from many countries race each other.

Leisel Jones -- A famous Australian swimmer who won many Olympic medals and held the old record.

Background you need

Australia is famous for producing world-class swimmers, like Ian Thorpe and Emma McKeon. The Australian Swimming Trials are where young talents earn their place on the national team.

Leisel Jones (an Australian swimming legend who won many Olympic medals) set the under-18 record in 2003, and it took 23 years for someone to beat it.

The super-suit era was a short time around 2008 when special plastic-like swimsuits helped swimmers go much faster; after they were banned, records became harder to break.

Break it down

WHO: Sienna Toohey, a 17-year-old swimmer from Albury, Australia.

WHAT: She broke the 23-year-old Australian record for the 100-meter breaststroke in her age group.

WHERE: At the Australian Swimming Trials.

WHY: Because she trained hard and exploded off the start, swimming faster than any other Australian teenager ever in that event.

Why it matters

Sienna shows that hard work and determination can help you achieve goals that seem impossible, and her story might inspire you never to give up on your own dreams, whether in sports, art, or school.

Test what you remember

1. Which swimming stroke did Sienna Toohey race?

- ☐ (A) Freestyle
- ☐ (B) Butterfly
- ☐ (C) Backstroke
- ☐ (D) Breaststroke

2. How old was Sienna when she broke the record?

- ☐ (A) 15
- ☐ (B) 16
- ☐ (C) 17
- ☐ (D) 18

3. Whose 23-year-old record did she beat?

- ☐ (A) Emma McKeon
- ☐ (B) Leisel Jones
- ☐ (C) Cate Campbell
- ☐ (D) Ariarne Titmus

4. By how much did Sienna beat the old record?

- ☐ (A) Exactly one second
- ☐ (B) Almost half a second
- ☐ (C) Two seconds
- ☐ (D) A quarter of a second

5. What were super-suits?

- ☐ (A) Normal swimsuits with bright colors
- ☐ (B) Special swimsuits that made swimmers faster
- ☐ (C) Extra clothes worn over a swimsuit to keep warm
- ☐ (D) Suits worn by superheroes

6. Where is Sienna from?

- ☐ (A) Sydney
- ☐ (B) Melbourne
- ☐ (C) Albury
- ☐ (D) Brisbane

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **Excited fan:** Swimming lovers see Sienna as a new star who can bring medals back to Australia. Breaking a record set by a legend is a huge sign of talent.
2. **Skeptical:** Some people say it is just an age-group record, not a world record, so it might not be that special. Others wonder if super-suits make later records seem less impressive, even though Leisel Jones swam before that era.
3. **Neutral observer:** Records are a way to measure how swimming has improved over time. Sienna's time shows that young athletes keep getting faster, and this is a normal part of sport.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):